

Prison X: A Revolution in Immersive Storytelling

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ABSTRACT

Prison X is an innovative VR experience transporting audiences into a mythological Neo-Andean underworld. As a foundational part of the Neo-Andean Metaverse, it translates Andean perspectives on time, space, philosophy, and mythology into an immersive 3D realm. This collaborative project by indigenous artists reclaims indigenous aesthetics using pioneering technology. The prison environment was created through photogrammetry and hand-painted in Tilt Brush then imported into Unity. Characters represent Andean futurism, designed based on pop culture and folklore. Animation utilizes motion capture while spatial audio and interactivity enhance immersion. Premiering at Sundance, Prison X combines storytelling, immersion and interactivity to innovate emerging film futurism. It explores anti-colonial narratives, challenging notions of identity and reality. The diversity of perspectives expands possibilities for XR as a tool of empowerment. Prison X points to an inclusive creative future, pioneering new visual language and storytelling.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Human-centered computing** → **Virtual reality**; • **Applied computing** → **Media arts**; • **Computing methodologies** → **Motion capture**.

KEYWORDS

Virtual reality, interactive narrative, indigenous storytelling, immersive film

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1 INTRODUCTION

Prison X is an innovative virtual reality experience transporting audiences into a mythological Neo-Andean underworld [Wikipedia 2023c]. As a foundational part of the emerging Neo-Andean Metaverse, it translates Andean perspectives on time, space, philosophy, and mythology into an immersive 3D realm [Holdsworth 2023]. This collaborative project conceived by indigenous artists reclaims indigenous aesthetics using pioneering technology [Cizek 2019].

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2 TECHNICAL APPROACH

The prison environment was first modeled physically then imported into VR through photogrammetry [Wikipedia 2023e]. It was hand-painted using Tilt Brush and brought into Unity's interactive engine to create an interactive setting true to an actual Bolivian prison [Tilt-Brush [n. d.]]. Characters embody Andean futurism, with designs based on Bolivian pop culture, folklore, Carnaval de Oruro and the unique architecture of El Alto [Wikipedia 2023b]. Their appearance plays with scale, inspired by Las Alasitas and integrated into the local contemporary context [Wikipedia 2023a]. Animation utilizes motion capture along with the Steam VR framework for expressive character movements [Gupta et al. 2020]. Spatial sound design, live music performances, and interactive tasks deepen immersion in the nonlinear narrative [Wikipedia 2023d]. Premiering at Sundance 2021, Prison X combines interactivity, immersion, and storytelling to innovate emerging practices of film futurism [Rosen 2020].

3 EMPOWERMENT THROUGH DIVERSITY

Prison X explores perspectives and worldviews typically excluded from digital media, questioning concepts of freedom, identity, and reality. It ultimately presents anti-colonial narratives through immersion, juxtaposing ancient mythology with the contemporary moment. This diversity of perspectives expands the possibilities for using XR as a tool for empowerment and social change.

4 CONCLUSION

Through technical innovation and homage to indigenous traditions, Prison X points to an inclusive creative future. It pioneers new visual language and storytelling for emerging practices of film futurism. The Neo-Andean metaverse presents diverse ways of understanding the world, virtually and philosophically. Prison X signifies the power of diversity and imagination in XR. It revolutionizes immersive storytelling across mediums, from ancestral roots to cutting-edge technology. This portal into collective liberation actualizes the potential of radical creativity.

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